

The Translation

She had spent twenty years translating other people's words. She had never translated herself.

CEFR Level B1

Book 1 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: London and Istanbul. Present day.

Genre: Literary Drama / Identity

Characters

- Elif — 38. Literary translator. Turkish-born, London-based. Precise and emotionally guarded.
- David — 44. Her editor at a small literary press. Patient, perceptive.
- Aunt Sevim — 72. Elif's aunt in Istanbul. The keeper of family stories.
- The author — Murat Aslan, a Turkish novelist whose difficult memoir Elif has been asked to translate.

Elif had translated seventeen novels, four collections of short stories, and two books of poetry over the course of her career. She had never refused a commission.

Until now.

David had slid the manuscript across the desk with the particular enthusiasm he reserved for projects he knew she would find difficult.

'Murat Aslan,' he said. 'You know his work?' 'I know of it,' Elif said carefully.

She had been avoiding Aslan's work for three years. His memoir, which had been published in Turkish to considerable controversy, was said to deal directly with the experience of leaving Istanbul — the same city, the same decade, almost the same streets as her own departure at the age of eighteen.

She had not read it. She had intended to keep not reading it.

controversy tartışma, polemik departure ayrılış reserved for... için saklı tutmak intended to niyet etmişti She had been avoiding this book for three years. David has just put it on her desk.

The problem was not the quality of the writing — Aslan was, by any measure, exceptional.

The problem was that his memoir covered the period between 1998 and 2004: Istanbul, the universities, the political arguments, the particular texture of being young in a city that was changing faster than its inhabitants could understand.

Elif had left Istanbul in 2001. She had not gone back for six years. When she finally returned, she had found a city that she recognised in its bones but no longer in its surface.

She had told herself, over the years, that she did not miss it. She had told herself this with considerable conviction, which should have been a warning.

manuscript home.

She did not open it that evening. She made dinner, read a different book, went to bed early.

In the morning, she found herself sitting at the kitchen table with the manuscript open at page one.

She had not decided to open it. Her hands had apparently made the decision without consulting her.

Aslan's first sentence was: 'The city I left has been demolished. In its place stands another city, wearing the same name like a borrowed coat.'

Elif set the manuscript down. She picked up her phone and called David.

'I'll do it,' she said.

Translating Aslan turned out to be unlike anything she had translated before.

Most literary translation, in Elif's experience, required a kind of controlled distance — you inhabited the author's voice without losing your own. The text was theirs; the English was yours.

Aslan's memoir refused this arrangement. His voice was so specific, so tied to a particular time and place, that inhabiting it felt less like wearing a costume and more like being slowly overtaken.

By the end of the first chapter, she had translated fourteen pages and rewritten six of them three times each.

She had also, without quite meaning to, remembered things she had believed she had forgotten.

ones she had worked hard to process — her parents' divorce, her decision to leave, the year she had spent sleeping on a friend's sofa in East London.

They were smaller. The smell of simit in the morning on the Galata Bridge. The particular sound of the call to prayer heard from a third-floor window. The way the Bosphorus looked on winter afternoons, grey and silver and merciless. She had not known, until she began translating Aslan, that she had kept these things intact somewhere — packed carefully in a place she had not thought to look.

She called her aunt Sevim in Istanbul.

Sevim was her father's older sister and the person in the family most likely to say something true.

'You're working on Aslan's book,' Sevim said, before Elif had said anything about it. 'I wondered when that would reach you.'

'How did you know?' 'Because I know you, and I know his book, and I knew this would happen eventually.'

Sevim had read the memoir twice. She had found it, she said, both accurate and infuriating.

'Accurate about what?' Elif asked.

'About what it was like. And infuriating because he gets to say it and we had to live it.' A pause. 'How far have you got?' 'Fourteen pages.' 'Fourteen pages and you're already calling me at eleven at night. That's a bad sign.'

The specific difficulty, which Elif had not anticipated and which she found almost impossible to explain to David, was this: Aslan wrote about Istanbul the way you write about something you have grieved and moved past.

Elif had not grieved it. She had simply left, efficiently and deliberately, and had spent twenty years not looking back.

Translating his grief — rendering it precisely, giving it the right weight and temperature in English — required her to acknowledge that the thing he was grieving was the same thing she had been declining to grieve.

This was not, she thought, a problem most translators encountered.

Chapter seven of Aslan's memoir described a specific evening in 2000 — a gathering of students at an apartment in Beyoglu, the long argument about whether leaving was a betrayal or a survival strategy, the walk home through streets that were being torn up for construction.

Elif had been at a similar gathering on a similar evening. She knew the argument. She had taken a side in it, firmly and with the confidence of someone who had not yet had to live the consequences.

The Translation



Elif receives a manuscript that brings London and Istanbul into the same room.

She translated the chapter in four hours, barely stopping. When she finished, she realised she had been crying at some point without noticing.

She was not sure exactly when it had started.

She sent David the first fifty pages two weeks after she had taken the commission.

He called her the following morning.

'This is extraordinary,' he said. 'It reads like you wrote it, not translated it.'

'That may be a problem,' Elif said.

'Why?' 'Because the line between translating and writing is supposed to be clear. If I can't find it anymore, I don't know what I'm doing.'

David was quiet for a moment. 'Do you think you've crossed it?' 'I don't know. I think I might have blurred it.'

'Send me the next fifty,' David said. 'We'll talk about it then.' He paused. 'The blurring might be the point, Elif.'

She went to Istanbul in March, ostensibly to consult Aslan about several passages she had found ambiguous.

Aslan turned out to be a quiet man in his fifties who seemed mildly surprised that she had wanted to meet at all. Most translators, he said, worked from the text and asked questions by email.

'I needed to see the city,' she admitted.

He looked at her with the expression of someone who had expected this and was pleased by the confirmation.

'You left in 2001,' he said. It was not a question.

'How did you know?' 'Because of the chapter you translated about the Beyoglu gathering. You translated the argument differently from how I wrote it. You were in that room.'

They met twice — once at his apartment, once at a cafe near the old university.

He was generous with his time and sparing with his opinions, which Elif found unusual in writers.

At the second meeting, he said: 'May I ask you something personal? You don't have to answer.'

'Ask.'

'Did you translate the grief chapters before or after you went back to the neighbourhood?'

Elif looked at her coffee. 'Before,' she said. 'I went back after.'

'And?'

'It was smaller than I remembered. The street was smaller. The apartment building had been repainted. It smelled different.'

Aslan nodded. 'Yes,' he said. 'That's what I tried to write. That specific loss.'

specific loss özgün kayıp repainted yeniden boyamış "That specific loss." The street was smaller. He had written it exactly. She had translated it exactly. Now she understood why.

walked streets she had not walked in years, ate things she had forgotten she had missed.

On the third day, she went to Beyoglu and found the apartment building where the gathering had taken place. The building was still there, though the top floor had been converted into something commercial.

She stood on the pavement outside for several minutes.

A woman was hanging laundry from a window on the second floor. She was singing quietly to herself, something Elif didn't recognise.

Elif thought: I should have come back sooner. Then she thought: I came back when I was ready. Then she thought: I wasn't ready. I came back because the book made me.

All three things were true.

was ready hazırdı She came back because the book made her. All three thoughts were true at once.

Back in London, she finished the translation in six weeks.

The Translation



As she translates, memory and language begin to overlap.

The grief chapters, which had stopped her at the beginning, now came more easily — not because she felt less, but because she had stopped trying to manage the distance between her feelings and the text.

She had understood, somewhere in Istanbul, that the translation required her presence, not her absence. That the best version of Aslan's grief in English was one that had passed through someone who understood it from the inside.

This was not how she had been taught to translate. She was not sure it was how translation was supposed to work. But it was what the book had needed.

'I want to ask you something,' he said, 'and I want you to answer honestly.'

'All right.'

'Did you write any of it?'

There was a silence.

'Define write,' Elif said.

'Did any sentences come from you rather than from Aslan?'

She thought about this carefully. About the grief chapters, about Istanbul, about the woman singing at the window.

'No,' she said. 'They all came from him. I just — translated them from the right place.'

David was quiet. Then: 'I think this might be the best translation I've published.'

the right place doğru yer silence sessizlik "Translated them from the right place." That is what David means by the best translation.

The reviews were, as David had predicted, considerable — several described it as the finest translation of contemporary Turkish literature to have appeared in English in a decade.

Elif read the reviews with the detachment she had trained herself to maintain, which was mostly genuine.

One reviewer wrote: 'The translator has achieved something rare — the English text does not feel like a translation at all, but like a book that had been written in English and somehow already existed in this form.'

Elif read that sentence twice.

She thought about the woman singing at the window in Beyoglu. She thought about the borrowed coat.

He said that he had read the English translation and found it accurate — 'accurate in the way that matters,' he wrote, 'which is not accuracy of word but accuracy of understanding.'

He said that he had not expected to be moved by a translation of his own work, since he already knew the story. He had been wrong.

He ended with a line that she kept.

'You translated the grief as someone who had carried a similar weight. I could feel that. It made the English text something I had not written but which was entirely mine.'

Sevim had, she said, already ordered a copy from an English bookshop online, though her English was functional at best.

'I want to read what you did with it,' Sevim said.

'You'll need a dictionary for most of it.'

'I have a dictionary. I'm seventy-two, not dead.' A pause.

'Are you all right? You sound different.'

'Different how?' 'Less defended. That might be the wrong word.'

'It might be the right one,' Elif said.

Sevim was quiet for a moment. 'Good,' she said.

Three months after publication, David sent her a new manuscript.

It was a novel by a young Korean writer — technically accomplished, emotionally restrained, about a subject she knew nothing about.

The Translation



By the water in Istanbul, she starts writing in her own voice.

She read the first chapter and felt the familiar sensation of entering a new voice, of finding the distance from which to translate.

The distance was there. Clean and professional and useful. She was glad to have it back.

She was also glad that she now knew it was a choice — not a permanent condition.

She began translating on a Tuesday morning, at the kitchen table, with a cup of tea cooling beside her.

She had been asked, at a literary festival in the autumn, to describe what translation meant to her.

She had given the standard answer — bridge between languages, service to the author, invisible art — and had felt, while giving it, that none of it was quite accurate.

Afterwards, in the taxi back to her hotel, she had tried to find the right words.

Translation was not a bridge. Bridges connected two separate banks without touching them.

Translation was more like — she had thought about this for a long time — translation was more like learning to hold two things at once without confusing them.

That was the skill. And sometimes, with the right text, it was also the education.

decided to go herself.

She stayed for ten days. She saw Sevim. She ate simit on the Galata Bridge and looked at the Bosphorus, which was grey and silver and merciless and completely itself.

On the last evening, she sat at a cafe table and opened her notebook.

She had been carrying a notebook for years but rarely written in it.

She wrote a sentence. Then another. Then she stopped and read them back.

They were hers. Not a translation. Hers.

She ordered another tea. She kept writing.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story so the reading pages remain in a natural storybook format.

1. commission	komisyon, görev
2. manuscript	el yazması, taslak
3. exceptional	olağanüstü
4. texture	doku
5. inhabitants	sakinler, halk
6. conviction	kesinlik, inanç
7. recognised in its bones	özünde tanıdı
8. cover a period	bir dönemi kapsamak
9. apparently	görünüşe göre
10. consulting	danışmak
11. demolished	yıkılmış
12. borrowed coat	ödünç palto
13. picked up	aldı
14. set down	bıraktı
15. inhabited	içinde yaşamak
16. arrangement	düzenleme
17. overtaken	ele geçirilmek
18. costume	kostüm
19. rewritten	yeniden yazmak
20. specific	özgün, belirli
21. process	işlemek (duygusal anlamda)
22. intact	sağlam, bozulmadan
23. merciless	acımasız
24. simit	simit
25. Bosphorus	Boğaz
26. packed carefully	dikkatle yerleştirilmiş
27. accurate	doğru, isabetli
28. infuriating	öfke verici
29. eventually	eninde sonunda
30. bad sign	kötü işaret
31. most likely to	en muhtemel
32. reached you	sana ulaştı
33. anticipated	öngörmüş
34. grieved	yas tutmak
35. rendering	aktarmak, çevirmek
36. declining to	reddetmek
37. temperature (figurative)	ağırlık, ton
38. encountered	karşılaştı

39. betrayal	ihamet
40. survival strategy	hayatta kalma stratejisi
41. gathering	toplantı, buluşma
42. consequences	sonuçlar
43. torn up	yıklmak, söküp atmak
44. barely stopping	neredeyse durmadan
45. extraordinary	olağanüstü
46. crossed a line	çizgiyi aşmak
47. blurred	bulanıklaşmış
48. supposed to be	... olması gerekiyor
49. the point	asıl mesele
50. might have	... olmuş olabilir
51. ostensibly	görünürde, sözde
52. ambiguous	belirsiz
53. confirmation	doğrulama
54. passages	bölümler, geçitler
55. mildly surprised	hafifçe şaşırmış
56. consult	danışmak
57. generous	cömert
58. sparing with opinions	görüşlerinde tutumlu
59. grief chapters	yas bölümleri
60. neighbourhood	mahalle
61. converted into	dönüştürülmüş
62. commercial	ticari
63. hanging laundry	çamaşır asmak
64. pavement	kaldırım
65. should have	... olmalıydı
66. manage the distance	mesafeyi yönetmek
67. presence	varlık, hazır bulunma
68. absence	yokluk, mesafe
69. passed through	içinden geçmek
70. was supposed to work	çalışması gerekirdi
71. from the inside	içeriden
72. honestly	dürüstçe
73. define	tanımlamak
74. came from	... den geldi
75. published	yayımladı
76. detachment	mesafe, tarafsızlık

77. contemporary	çağdaş
78. fine	olağanüstü
79. predicted	öngörmüştü
80. rare	nadir
81. somehow	bir şekilde
82. appropriate	uygun
83. accuracy of understanding	anlama doğruluğu
84. moved by	... tarafından etkilenmek
85. carried a similar weight	benzer bir yük taşımak
86. entirely	tamamen
87. kept the line	satırı korudu
88. functional	işlevsel (dil için)
89. at best	en iyi ihtimalle
90. defended	korunaklı, savunmacı
91. sound different	farklı ses çıkarmak
92. less defended	daha az savunmacı
93. already ordered	çoktan sipariş etti
94. technically accomplished	teknik olarak başarılı
95. restrained	kısıtlanmış, tutumlu
96. familiar sensation	tanıdık his
97. permanent condition	kalıcı durum
98. glad to have it back	geri sahip olmaktan memnun
99. cooling	soğuyor
100. literary festival	edebiyat festivali
101. invisible art	görünmez sanat
102. quite accurate	tam doğru
103. confusing them	karıştırmak
104. skill	beceri
105. hold two things at once	ikisini aynı anda tutmak
106. decided to go herself	gitmek için kendisi karar verdi
107. carrying a notebook	defter taşımak
108. rarely written	nadiren yazmış
109. completely itself	tamamen kendisi
110. kept writing	yazmaya devam etti

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase

Meaning

1. commission

A. belirsiz

2. ambiguous

B. görev, sipariş

3. betrayal

C. ihanet

4. conviction

D. kesinlik, inanç

5. grieved

E. yas tutmak

6. detachment

F. mesafe, tarafsızlık

7. inhabited

G. içinde yaşamak

8. restrained

H. kısıtlanmış, tutumlu

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

translated — distance — grief — blurred — defended —
presence

1. Elif had _____ seventeen novels before she was asked to work on Aslan's memoir.

**2. She realised that the translation required her _____,
not her absence.**

**3. David said the line between translating and writing had
been _____.**

4. Translating his _____ required her to acknowledge her own unfelt loss.

5. Sevim said Elif sounded 'less _____' after the translation was finished.
6. Most literary translation required a kind of controlled _____ from the text.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Elif had read Aslan's memoir before she was asked to translate it. ____

2. Aslan's memoir covers the period 1998-2004. ____

3. Elif left Istanbul in 1995. ____

4. David thinks the blurring of translation and writing is a problem. ____
5. Aslan guessed that Elif had been at the Beyoglu gathering. ____
6. At the end, Elif writes her own words in a notebook. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why had Elif been avoiding Aslan's memoir?
8. What is the specific translation difficulty Elif faces with this memoir?
9. What does Aunt Sevim mean when she says the book is 'infuriating'?
10. Why does Elif go to Istanbul in March?
11. How does Aslan know that Elif was at the Beyoglu gathering?
12. What does Elif mean by translating the grief 'from the right place'?
13. What does Aslan write to Elif after reading the English translation?
14. How does Elif describe translation at the end — what is the metaphor she finds?
15. What is the significance of Elif writing her own words at the end?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. translated 2. presence 3. blurred 4. grief 5. defended 6. distance

True / False: 1. F 2. T 3. F 4. F 5. T 6. T

7. Because his memoir covered the same period and city as her own departure from

Istanbul — it was too close to her own experience.

8. His grief about Istanbul is the same grief she has been refusing to feel — to translate

it precisely, she has to acknowledge her own unfelt loss.

9. Because he gets to say publicly what they all had to live privately — she finds that

both honest and frustrating.

10. Ostensibly to consult Aslan about ambiguous passages, but really because she

needed to see the city.

11. Because she translated the argument in that chapter differently from how he had

written it — as someone who had been in the room.

12. She stopped managing the distance between her feelings and the text, and allowed

her own understanding of Istanbul to inform the English.

13. That the translation was accurate in understanding, not just in word — and that it

moved him even though he knew the story.

14. Not a bridge — but holding two things at once without confusing them.

15. For the first time, she is writing her own words rather than translating someone

else's — she has found her own voice after twenty years.